

Contrast in genius: While Kohli embodied the smoke and magic nature of T20 cricket as it began Rohit encapsulated what the format became: fire and brimstone.

Pics: K. R. DEEPAK

the batting conditions. His 92 against Australia in St. Lucia was the third-highest score of the tournament, and his crucial 57 against England helped India post a competitive total on a difficult, turning pitch in the semifinal in Georgetown, Guyana.

Even in the final against South Africa, he fell cheaply while attempting his favoured sweep shot against Keshav Maharaj in the second over, but not before smacking him for two consecutive boundaries, including one reverse sweep. **Rohit's strike rate in the PowerPlay was consistently above 140, often setting the tempo for the rest of the team.**

This aggressive style also benefitted Rohit's opening partner, Kohli, allowing him time to assess the conditions before accelerating. Despite a challenging campaign this World Cup, where he scored only 75 runs in seven innings, Kohli delivered when it mattered most. His crucial knock in the final helped India reach a formidable total of 176-7.

Kohli started briskly, hitting three beautifully timed boundaries off Marco Jansen in the first over of the innings.

However, with India having lost three wickets for just 34 runs in the PowerPlay, he had to adapt his approach to a more cautious one. The progression of his innings in the final illustrates this shift:

🌟 **First 5 balls: 14 runs**

🌟 **Next 43 balls: 36 runs**

🌟 **Last 11 balls: 26 runs**

Kohli's greatest asset in white-ball cricket has been his ability to break down targets into manageable goals. However, the rapid evolution of T20 cricket eventually caught up with him. The demand for higher strike rates and a less risk-averse approach meant his recent years in T20Is were a slow burn, with occasional brilliance like his 53-ball



82 against Pakistan in Melbourne (2022 T20 World Cup) or his 59-ball 76 against South Africa. These performances reminded us of his greatness, and we celebrated them with a certain reserve — less jubilant, more appreciative.

At 35, despite his numerous achievements, Kohli pushed himself to meet modern T20 demands, showcasing his insatiable drive to be the best. This relentless pursuit will be his lasting T20I legacy.

Rohit, on the other hand, will be remembered for acknowledging that T20 cricket has evolved more in the last three years than in the previous decade.

While this may sound simple, it represents a multilayered challenge, especially considering that the team he was leading was a side that was traditionally focused on preserving wickets before launching an attack in the latter overs.

But when the demand to go big from the start appeared like Stanley Kubrick's monolith from the cult classic *2001: Space Odyssey*, triggering a shift in evolution, Rohit was front and centre of that transition, leading by example.

When India defends its T20 World Cup title at home in 2026, Kohli and Rohit will not be part of the

squad. Yet, the new team will be building on an edifice that their exalted predecessors laid the foundation for.

